

Briefing: Public toilets - Action Plan Update

Health and Social Care Scrutiny Commission

27th January 2026

Background

This report provides an update on the work the council is doing to improve public toilet provision in Southwark. In October 2024 a cabinet report was presented in response to the review of public toilet provision in Southwark carried out by the Health and Social Care Scrutiny Commission. Nine recommendations were made aimed addressing gaps in toilet provision, especially for vulnerable groups. The recommendations impact multiple council departments and require a coordinated response. The paper below sets out the ongoing cross departmental work.

Update

The management and development of council managed public toilet facilities across the borough is carried out by several different council departments. Officers from 10 different teams have been brought together to form a public toilet working group. The group meet once a quarter and membership also includes a resident of southwark who is involved in the campaign for improved public toilet provision.

The aims of the group are to;

- Deliver and develop the actions in the Toilet Action Plan (see appendix 1)
- Improve the standards of provision of the council's existing public toilets (See appendix 2)
- Work with businesses and the wider community to improve the number of public toilets available
- Improve communications to inform residents and visitors where they can find a public toilet
- Where possible/feasible provide additional public toilets particularly in areas of low provision

Table 1 - Role and Responsibilities of teams who form the Toilet Working Group

Team	Role
Parks and Natural Environment Team	day-to-day operations of public toilets across parks and open spaces.
Asset Management	day to day operations of public toilets in Council office buildings such as Tooley St and Queens Road
Leisure Centres Team	day-to-day operations of public toilets across leisure centres
Culture Team	day-to-day operations of public toilets across libraries
Local Economy Team	responsible for engagement with local businesses
Comms Team	development and delivery of the communications plan
Consultation and involvement Team	linking the working group and the Toilet Action plan to stakeholder groups
Sustainable Growth	allocation of CiL and S106 funding which can be used for public toilet improvements
Community Safety	raising awareness and reducing anti social behaviour in public toilets
Public Health Team	providing insight on the needs and requirements of target groups

Annual review – a consistent approach

Through working collaboratively, the group also contribute to an annual programme of work to ensure that the data and information that the council shares is current and up to date and that the Toilet Action Plan continues to evolve.

Table 2 - programme of data checks and communications

Action	Purpose	Time frame
Working Group membership	Update the membership of the working group to ensure the right officers are included, send out diary invites	Annually (Apr)
Data refresh	Update the council's public toilet data spreadsheet to ensure all of the information is correct	Annually (Apr)
Toilet Map update	Once the data has been checked then any changes are to be updated on the toilet map online	Annually (Apr)
Google maps update	Update where possible information regarding the council's public toilets on Google Maps	Annually (Apr)
Web check	Council 'Public Toilet' web page is checked for accuracy and that links still work	Annually (Apr)
Comms refresh	Re distribution of comms materials and reposting of social media, parks to check notice boards etc.	Bi Annually (May & Nov)
Call to action for local businesses	In addition to the ongoing work by Local Town Centre Team, a call to action to be included in the e-newsletter to businesses	Annually

Investment

In addition to the ongoing delivery of the Toilet Action plan, officers across a number of teams have been working on various investment projects to either improve existing council public toilets or deliver new ones. Below are the projects that have either been delivered or are in the process of being delivered.

Existing - Peckham Rye Park - Peckham Rye Park's existing public toilet block is to be refurbished this spring, delivering a safe, inclusive and durable amenity for park visitors. Estimated to open in April 2026.

The current facilities have not been refurbished for many years and have been subject to numerous arson attacks and antisocial behaviour incidents. The equipment and finishes are now damaged beyond repair and deep clean. The layout is restrictive and unwelcoming.

The objective of the refurbishment is to provide good quarterly facilities that require low maintenance, have strong anti-vandal fixtures and facilities. Once the project has been completed the toilets will reopen from 7.30-21.00 in the summer and to dusk in the winter. They will be subject to a daily cleaning regime operated through the Corporate Facilities Maintenance Contract.

Existing - East Street Market toilets – Officers are currently exploring a refurbishment project to improve the public toilets in the busy East Street market. The facilities are dated and subject to incidents of anti social behaviour. Plans and costs have been developed and officers are currently exploring opportunities for funding.

Existing – Dulwich Library – The refurbishment of Dulwich library is currently underway and due for completion in July 2026. Part of the project is the refurbishment of the ground floor public toilets (including 1 accessible toilet); however, there will also be an additional toilet installed on the first floor.

New provision - Brandon Library – As part of the refurbishment of the Brandon Estate Library is the provision of a new accessible public toilet. Works on the library are due to begin in February and will be completed in the summer.

New provision - Canada Water Leisure Centre - The council's new leisure centre opened in autumn last year. The facility includes a fully accessible new public toilet in the reception area, before the barriers to enter the facility. In addition to this, the centre also provides a Changing Places toilet which, whilst located within the centre, is open for use by anyone needing to use the changing places toilet.

Officers across the council continue to explore the potential for the provision of new public toilets where feasible and sustainable, particularly in relation to the development of new public building and facilities.

Challenges

The OSC report also made the recommendation to revive the council's Community Toilet Scheme. Unfortunately, the position on this remains the same, which is that while much work is underway, with toilet information consolidated on the Great British Toilet Map and engagement with businesses ongoing, there is currently no budget for a more formal scheme with businesses. Benchmarking of the scheme in other areas shows that, success requires a need for monitoring and financial incentives for business to cover costs.

The report also recommended the development of a comprehensive strategy through stakeholder engagement and mapping and the response was to commit to delivering an Accessible Toilet Plan that will ensure fair access, up-to-date information, and business engagement.

Despite the resource challenges, there has been progress on the council's work to improving public toilet provision. This includes:

1. A more coordinated and collaborative cross departmental approach to the council's work on improving public toilet provision.
2. Completion of a number of capital investment schemes to improve provision of public toilets - with more to follow.
3. Consolidation of data on public toilets and updating of the information on the Toilet Map online.
4. The imminent delivery of a new council campaign, signposting residents on how they can find out where their nearest public toilet is, should they need one.
5. A refreshed focus on working with local business to encourage them to provide public access to their customer toilets.

Appendix 1. Toilet Action Plan

LBS Public Toilet Action Plan				
Action	Lead	Status	Comments	Next steps
1. Governance				
1.A) Develop an Accessible Toilet Plan to improve and ensure fair access to toilet facilities across the borough.	Tara Quinn	Completed	This document is the councils Toilet Access Plan. Reviewed quarterly at the toilet working group meeting. It is a working and dynamic document	Next review 26 Jan 2026 at quarterly Toilet Working Group meeting
1.B) Report on the progress of the Accessible Toilet Plan to the Health and Social Care Scrutiny Commission	Tara Quinn	In progress	Report back on progress with delivering recommendations - scheduled for Jan 2026 - slightly delayed due to resourcing challenges	Feedback to the Toilet Working group outcomes and any actions from Scrutiny meeting. Incorporate any actions into action plan
1.C) Set up Toilet Working Group	Tara Quinn	Completed	Meets Quarterly to: Oversee the development and delivery of the Toilet Action Plan Improve standards of provision and communications Report on issues with provision Update on opportunities for further funding and investment Update on capital investment projects Ensure that the provision of public toilets is considered as part	Next meeting 26 Jan 2026

			of resident focused services delivery	
2. Existing Council provision:				
2.A) Ensure adequate access to toilets in council offices, libraries, leisure centres, parks, and sports grounds.	Teams - Leisure Centres, Libraries, Corp Facility Management, Parks, Outdoor Recreation	Ongoing	Responsible for monitoring and improving the cleaning and maintenance of the public toilets in their service areas Responsible for ensuring staff permit access to toilets that are behind access barriers where necessary (leisure centres that don't have a pre barrier public toilet) Responsible for assisting with the annual update of maps, online info and comms.	Prepare for annual update process Parks Team - Look into incorporating FixMyStreet into comms messages to improve public reporting on toilet cleanliness/maintenance.
2.B) Consider increasing the frequency of cleaning library toilets, subject to resource implications.	Libraries, Corp Facility Management	Completed	Toilets deep cleaned and ongoing cleaning frequency is adequate. Monitoring is in place.	Review in April 2026
3. Mapping				

3.A) Create database of Council's public toilets	Project Officer	Completed	Have a single point of information on info about council provided public toilets, updated annually for accuracy, location, opening hours and facilities etc.	Next update due April 2026
3.B) Update the 'Toilet Map' to ensure locations and info are correct	Project Officer	Completed	Ensure that the location of council provided toilets on the 'toilet map' are correct and accurate and then reviewed annually	Next update due April 2026
3.C) Update google maps on locations and info about council provided public toilets	Project officers/comms/IT	Ongoing	Ensure that the location of council provided toilets on 'google maps' are correct and accurate and then reviewed annually.	Next update due April 2026
3.D) Undertake a gap analysis to identify toilet provision cold spots	Project Officer	In progress	This could only be completed once the data had been cleaned. then a gap analysis to be completed in order to find toilet cold spots in the borough. Accurate position is now known and gap analysis to be completed subject to resource	
4. Comms:				
4.A) Publicise the Great British Toilet Map on the council's website to provide information on accessible toilet locations.	Project Officer	Completed	The Toilet Map link is updated on council website. The website page has been updated to inform people where to find public toilets but also to encourage local businesses to open up their	Next review - April 2026

			customers toilets as public toilets	
4.B) Establish a full annually updated Comms Plan	Comms Team	In progress	Comms plan completed Southwark Public Toilet comms designs completed	Launch of new comms campaign in Spring 2026 Look into incorporating FixMyStreet into comms messages to improve public reporting on toilet cleanliness/maintenance. Next update of comms plan - Summer 2026 (incorporating learning and monitoring from Spring Campaign) Officers to carry out a review of street signage to identify gaps
4.C) Improve information - Signposting visitors of parks that do not have public toilets to the nearest public toilets	Parks Team	In progress	Parks officers are putting up information in 23 parks notice boards in parks/green spaces with no toilets making visitors aware of where the nearest council public toilet is. This will be completed by Feb 6th.	Review posters annually Check posters are still in parks public notice boards Check the information is correct
5. Business Engagement:				
5.A) Include the action to improve public toilet provision in Town Centre Action Plans	Local Economy Team	Completed		Review annually

5.B) Include a call for businesses to open up their customers toilets to the public in the Local Economy Team e-newsletter	Local Economy Team	Completed	Business e-newsletter sent to approx.12,000 Southwark businesses in May 2025. Aim is include the call to action in the e-newsletter 1-2 times a year.	Monitor update via the Toilet map and through feedback from businesses
5.C) Include action to improve access to public toilets in works plans of all town centre managers	Local Economy Team	In progress	Starting 1st April 2026 (building on previous work and conversations) Town centre managers to work together on how this can be approached	Review of progress in Oct 2026
5.D) Collaborate with key stakeholders like Age UK and local businesses/hospitals for the Accessible Toilet Plan.	All	Ongoing	Officers attended a workshop looking at Community Toilet Schemes in London in Oct 2025 and provided feedback to the Toilet Working Group Toilet Action Plan and Working Group has been linked in with the officers working on Southwark's Age friendly Borough Agenda and also Southwark Pensioners Action Group	Officers to follow up Asset Management leads in the NHS to explore opportunities for more public toilet provision and communication of public toilets by the NHS. Officers to continue seeking opportunities for partnership working, improving communication to target groups
6. Planning:				

6.A) Provide new public toilets as part of the new square at Peckham Rye Station.	Planning Team	Ongoing	Whilst the original (2016) planning consent for the Peckham Rye Station Square scheme included provision for public WCs, these were subsequently removed from the scope of the project due to land assembly, capital and revenue cost constraints and are no longer included within the scheme currently being delivered. However, public WCs are available in a number of other public buildings within the town centre including Peckham Pulse Leisure Centre, the Library and Peckham Levels. Further public WCs, including Changing Places-standard WCs, will also be delivered at Peckham Rye station as part of Network Rail's major station upgrade scheme which was subsequently granted planning consent in 2023, however timescale for delivery of this remains to be confirmed dependent upon full Government	Planning officers to keep the working group updated on the Network Rail Project
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			funding approval.	
6.B) Widen public access to toilet provision when undertaking works on existing or new buildings.	All	Ongoing	All officers to consider opportunities for the provision of new front facing public toilets when carrying out major works on council buildings. Good examples have been Canada Water Leisure Centre, Brandon library.	Working group to work with Sustainable Growth Team to identify future opportunities
7. Operational Challenges/ASB:				
7.A) Work with Community Safety Team to address any ASB issues in public toilets	Operational Teams and Community Safety Team	Ongoing	Operators to monitor antisocial behaviour and share information with wardens and safe neighbourhood teams. Park Liaison Officers now include the public toilets as part of	Officers to work with community safety on the recording of ASB that is specific to public toilets (non staffed)

			their patrol routes	
7.B) Publicise how visitors can report ASB in toilets that are not in staffed buildings	Operational Teams and Community Safety Team	Completed	Operational Teams to ensure new community safety posters are displayed in public toilets	Check every 6 months and refresh where necessary

Appendix 2. List of council managed public toilets

Area	Site	Facilities also include
Bankside and Walworth	Portland Street (East Street Market) Public Toilets	Disabled Toilet
Bankside and Walworth	Southwark Heritage Centre and Walworth Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	The Castle Leisure Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing, Changing Places
Bankside and Walworth	Tooley Street Offices	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	Una Marson Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	Geraldine Mary Harmsworth Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	John Harvard Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	Burgess Chumleigh Gdns	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	Burgess Fishing Lake	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	Burgess Sports Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bankside and Walworth	Burgess Tennis pavilion	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bermondsey and Rotherhithe	Blue Anchor Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bermondsey and Rotherhithe	Southwark Park	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bermondsey and Rotherhithe	Southwark Park Athletics Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bermondsey and Rotherhithe	Surrey Docks Watersports Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Bermondsey and Rotherhithe	Canada Water Leisure Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing, changing places
Bermondsey and Rotherhithe	Canada Water Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing, Changing Places
Camberwell and Dulwich	Belair Park Toilet	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Camberwell Leisure Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Camberwell Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Grove Vale Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Kingswood Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Dulwich Leisure Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Dulwich Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Dulwich Park Bike Hire Toilet Block	Disabled Toilet
Camberwell and Dulwich	Dulwich Park Central Area Toilet Block	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Camberwell and Dulwich	Dulwich Park Changing Places Toilet	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing, Changing Places
Camberwell and Dulwich	Dulwich Park Francis Peek Community Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Peckham and Nunhead	Camberwell New Cemetery Columbarium	Disabled Toilet
Peckham and Nunhead	Camberwell Old Cemetery	Disabled Toilet
Peckham and Nunhead	Honor Oak Crematorium	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Peckham and Nunhead	Nunhead Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Peckham and Nunhead	Peckham Library	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Peckham and Nunhead	Peckham Pulse Leisure Centre	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing, Changing Places
Peckham and Nunhead	Peckham Rye Park	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Peckham and Nunhead	Peckham Rye Park Nearest Playroom	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing
Peckham and Nunhead	Queens Rd Peckham Offices	Disabled Toilet, Baby Changing